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THA 101: Traditional African Theatre - Festival, Ritual and Performance

Read African festival theatre as a complete performance system, not as folklore

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 100L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

THA 101 is where the department teaches you that African theatre did not begin with a written script. This pack explains festival theatre as a total performance event - space, audience, music, costume, masquerade and participation - and shows you how to describe a performance you have witnessed with precision instead of vague praise.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Define traditional African theatre and distinguish it from written dramatic literature.
- Analyse a festival performance using space, audience, performer, music, costume and participation.
- Explain how ritual structure shapes the organisation of an African festival.
- Describe the masquerade tradition without treating it as mere entertainment.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

What counts as traditional African theatre

Traditional theatre is performance made by a community, for that community, in a form inherited and adapted rather than written down by a single author.

- The performance is usually tied to a calendar, a rite of passage or a season, not to a ticketed evening.
- Text may be minimal; meaning is carried by movement, music, mask, costume and audience response.
- There is no sharp line between performers and spectators: the community participates.
- The performance often has a social function - purification, harvest thanksgiving, initiation, conflict resolution.

- Continuity comes from apprenticeship and participation, not from published scripts.

> **Avoid two mistakes**
> Do not treat African festival theatre as primitive entertainment, and do not romanticise it as untouched tradition. It changes with its community and has always absorbed new elements.

Festival as total theatre

Total theatre means every performance element carries meaning at once.

- Space: the market square, shrine, compound or village green is the stage, and its meaning changes the performance.
- Music: drums and song cue entrances, control tempo and mark transitions.
- Costume and mask: they identify status, spirit or character, and may transform the wearer.
- Movement and dance: patterned movement carries narrative and community identity.
- Audience: response, chorus and participation complete the performance.
- Time: festivals often run for days, so duration itself is part of the form.

Writing about a performance

Assessment rewards specific observation. Use this structure for any performance report.

1. State what you saw, where and on what occasion.
2. Describe the performance space and how it was used.
3. Identify performers, costumes and masks, and what each communicated.
4. Analyse music and movement as structural devices, not decoration.
5. Describe audience participation and how it shaped the event.
6. Evaluate the performance's social purpose and your evidence for that claim.